

THE DOCTRINE OF THE ETHIOPIAN ORTHODOX TEWAHEDO CHURCH REGARDING THE VIRGIN MARY:

(1) The Virgin Mary is the Mother of God “Theotokos” Our Church cherishes the name of the Virgin Mary the Mother of God. This name is taken from the Holy Bible and not from human thinking or ideas. It is a divine declaration.

Isaiah the Prophet said: “Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a Son, and shall call His name Immanuel” (Isaiah 7:14) “Immanuel which is translated “God with us” (Matthew 1:23). “And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us.” (John 1:14).

† When Elizabeth received the Virgin Mary carrying our Lord in her womb, she was filled with the Holy Spirit and said: “But why is this granted to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me?” (Luke 1:43) then the baby leaped in her womb from joy and worshipping of His Lord.

† The prophecy of the Angels to the Shepherds is seen, “For there is born to you this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.” (Luke 2:11).

† In the prophecy of the Angel to the Virgin Mary, the Angel said: “He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Highest; and the Lord God will give Him the throne of His father David. And He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of His kingdom there will be no end.” (Luke 1:32-33)

(2) THE VIRGIN MARY OF THE PERPETUAL VIRGINITY “EPARTHENOS”

† What the angel said in his words when he came to Mary: “Now in the sixth month the angel Gabriel was sent by God to a city of Galilee named Nazareth, to a virgin betrothed to a man whose name was Joseph, of the house of David. The virgin's name was Mary.” (Luke 1:26-27). The word “virgin” in Greek is “Eparthenos” and in Hebrew is “Alma”. Both the Greek and Hebrew words mean “Perpetual virginity” because she gave birth to the Saviour of the World and her virginity remained intact.

† Some of the traditional stories of the church that tell us when the Virgin Mary entered the temple after giving birth to the Lord, she stood in the rows of the virgins and when they tried to prevent her from that, Zakariah the priest told them to leave her there in the row of virgins.

† In the commemoration of Saints in the Divine Liturgy we say: “the Ever Virgin Mary” i.e. The perpetual virgin.

† The symbol of St. Mary's virginity is the burning bush that Moses saw on the mountain since her womb was the carrier of the divine and human and she was not burnt by the divine nature “And the Angel of the LORD appeared to him in a flame of fire from the midst of a bush. So he looked, and behold, the bush was burning with fire, but the bush was not consumed.” (Exodus 3:2).

(3) THE VIRGIN MARY IS THE SECOND HEAVEN

The Heaven is the throne of God. The Virgin Mary carried God inside her and that is why she was called the “Second Heaven”. The word of God's swelling in Greek is “Episkiazo” (meaning overshadow) and in Hebrew “Shakan” (meaning dwelling).

Those are the words used in the Holy Bible to express the dwelling of God in the tabernacle in the Old Testament. “Then the cloud covered the tabernacle of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle. And Moses was not able to enter the tabernacle of meeting, because the cloud rested above it, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle.” (Exodus 40:34-35). This is the same word used during the transfiguration “And a cloud came and overshadowed them; and a voice came out of the cloud, saying: “This is My beloved Son. Hear Him!” (Mark 9:7).

In the good tidings from the Archangel Gabriel to the Virgin Mary he said: “The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Highest will overshadow you; therefore, also, that Holy One who is to be born will be called the Son of God.” (Luke 1:35).

ETHIOPIAN ORTHODOX TEWAHEDO DOCTRINE IN INTERCESSION.

DEFINITION OF INTERCESSION IN GENERAL:

Intercession is mediation. For instance a person with influence would mediate on behalf of another person and submit his request to the King or a person of power. From this simple example we find all the elements of intercession. A small person or someone in a small position has a request to submit to the king or a great person, but because he feels that he does not deserve it, he may submit his request with some enforcement or recommendation from another person who has influence over the king so that he may find grace in the king's eyes.

There are three kinds of intercession in the spiritual life:

1) RANSOM (PROPITIATORY) INTERCESSION:

“For there is one God and one Mediator between God and men, the Man Christ Jesus, Who gave Himself a ransom for all, to be testified in due time” (1 Timothy 2:5-6) St. John says also “And if anyone sins, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous. And He Himself is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the whole world.” (1 John 2:1-2).

The human nature perished and death entered into human lives. Jesus' blood on the Cross was the price for this sin so that Man can stand with condemnation before God. No one can stand before God without sin, because everyone was lost and perished and needed the glory of God. But through the Ransom Intercession of Our Lord Jesus Christ, man can stand before God without condemnation because he believed in the blood of Jesus Christ. All the offering in the Old Testament was a symbol for the Offering that was made on the Cross “Behold! The Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!” (John 1:29) St. John the Evangelist in the book of Revelation saw the people who benefited from the intercession of the blood of Jesus when he said: “These are the ones who come out of the great tribulation, and washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.” (Revelation 7:14).

2) ENTREATING INTERCESSION:

Because God loved us and called us His children, He told His disciples when you pray you say: “Our Father Who art in heaven ...” Do we deserve to be called children of God when we go about in our lives not careful about our spiritual life and we have repeated sins? Of course we do not deserve to be called children of God, and we lost our influence (favour) as children because of our many sins and breaking God's commandments. What happens to us when we face tribulation or get sick while we have lost our influence that we have WITH GOD? CAN WE BOLDLY ask Him? We still pray to Him and ask Him, but at the same time we ask from the Saints to pray for us and we say in the song of “Rejoice O Mary ...” “we have no favour with Jesus Christ Our Lord except your request and intercession, You Our Lady the Mother of God ...” In the Holy Bible it says; “I honour who honours me” and truly, the Virgin Mary, the angels and Saints have honoured the Lord and He honours them when they ask Him on our behalf.

EXAMPLES OF INTERCESSION FROM THE OLD TESTAMENT

† Abraham intercedes on behalf of Sodom and Gomorrah in Genesis 18:16-33 “And the LORD said, “Shall I hide from Abraham what I am doing” (Genesis 18:17). To this point, God loves Abraham because of his obedience, while Sodom and Gomorrah was filled with evil and corruption. Abraham started talking to God and asking Him to forgive the two cities if he found even 10 righteous people and the Lord listened to Abraham. But Abraham could not find even 10 people “Then the LORD rained brimstone and fire on Sodom and Gomorrah, from the LORD out of the heavens.” (Genesis 19:24).

† Elisha the Prophet asked on behalf of his disciple “LORD, I pray, open his eyes that he may see.” Then the LORD opened the eyes of the young man, and he saw.” (2 Kings 6:8). Then when they entered Samaria he prayed again “So it was, when they had come to Samaria, that Elisha said, “LORD, open the eyes of these men that they may see.” And the LORD opened their eyes, and they saw” (2 Kings 6:20).

† During the time of Solomon the King (the son of David), when Solomon sinned against the Lord, God wanted to divide the kingdom, but He said not during Solomon's time “for the sake” of David my slave because God had a good relation with David and He said “I found his heart according to my heart.”

EXAMPLES OF INTERCESSION IN THE NEW TESTAMENT

The intercession of the Virgin Mary at the wedding of Cana of Galilee where the Lord performed His first miracles through the intercession of the Virgin Mary when he transformed the water into wine and sadness into happiness. It so happened that the people at the wedding asked from the Virgin Mary to intercede on their behalf. (John 2:1-11).

† St. Paul asks for the prayer of the people of the Church for him “Therefore I exhort first of all that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks be made for all men, for kings and all who are in authority, that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and reverence. For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Savior, who desires all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.” (1 Timothy 2:1-4).

3) THE INTERCESSION OF THE POOR:

Donating and helping the poor is a great deed and a great intercession for us with the Lord Our Saviour.

† Matthew 25:34-46: “Then the King will say to those on His right hand, “Come, you blessed of My Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world: for I was hungry and you gave Me food; I was thirsty and you gave Me drink; ... when did we see You hungry and feed You, or thirsty and give You drink? ... Assuredly, I say to you, inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brethren, you did it to Me.”

† “He who has pity on the poor lends to the LORD, and He will pay back what he has given.” (Proverbs 19:17).

† “Make friends for yourselves by unrighteous mammon.” (Luke 16:9).

† “Blessed is he who considers the poor; the LORD will deliver him in time of trouble. The LORD will preserve him and keep him alive, and he will be blessed on the earth; you will not deliver him to the will of his enemies. The LORD will strengthen him on his bed of illness; you will sustain him on his sickbed.” (Psalm 41:1-3).